Unit 2

Chorales

New: Four voices on two staves; chords on every degree of the scale, and first inversions

A chorale is a hymn tune harmonised in four voices: soprano, alto, tenor and bass. On the piano the right hand plays the soprano (stems up) and the alto (stems down) on the treble staff, and the left hand plays the tenor (stems up) and the bass (stems down) on the bass staff. Every beat is a new chord, so you read vertically: one chord at a time, top to bottom, then the next.

Bach harmonised hundreds of chorales, and organists and church pianists have read them at sight for three hundred years. They are the best training there is for reading chords.

What is new

Four voices on two staves

Soprano and alto share the treble staff, tenor and bass the bass staff. Stems up for the higher voice of each pair, stems down for the lower.

Chords on every degree

Besides I, IV and V you will meet ii (D F A in C major) and vi (A C E), and V7. In a minor key the chords are i, iv, V (with the raised 7th) and VI.

First inversion

A chord with its third in the bass, such as C major with E in the bass, is in first inversion. It sounds lighter than a root-position chord and helps the bass move by step.

Fermatas

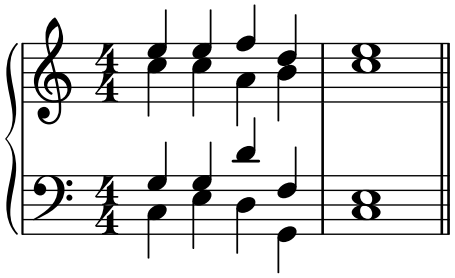
A fermata (a dot under an arch) marks the end of a line of the hymn. Hold the chord a little longer, breathe, and start the next line in time.

When the left hand can't reach

Sometimes the tenor sits more than an octave above the bass. Then the right hand takes the tenor note: an old organist's trick that every chorale player uses.

One chord, four voices

Soprano E, alto C (right hand); tenor G, bass C (left hand). Then the same chord in first inversion (E in the bass), then ii (D F A), V7 and I. The 7th of V7 (F, in the tenor) falls to E.
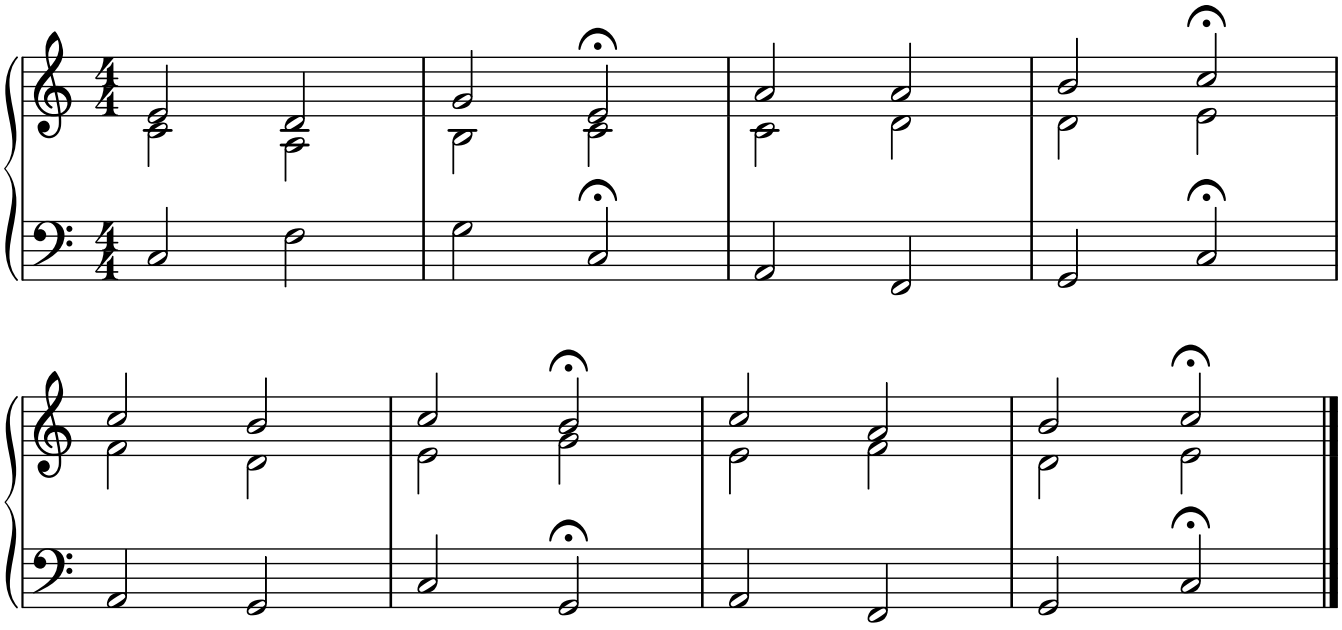


Reading tips

1. Read each chord from the bass up: it tells you which chord it is and whether it is inverted.
2. Most voices move by step or stay on the same note. Look for the notes that don't move: hold them.
3. Breathe at every fermata, as a choir would, but keep the beat underneath.
4. If four voices are too many at first, play soprano and bass only, then add the inner voices.

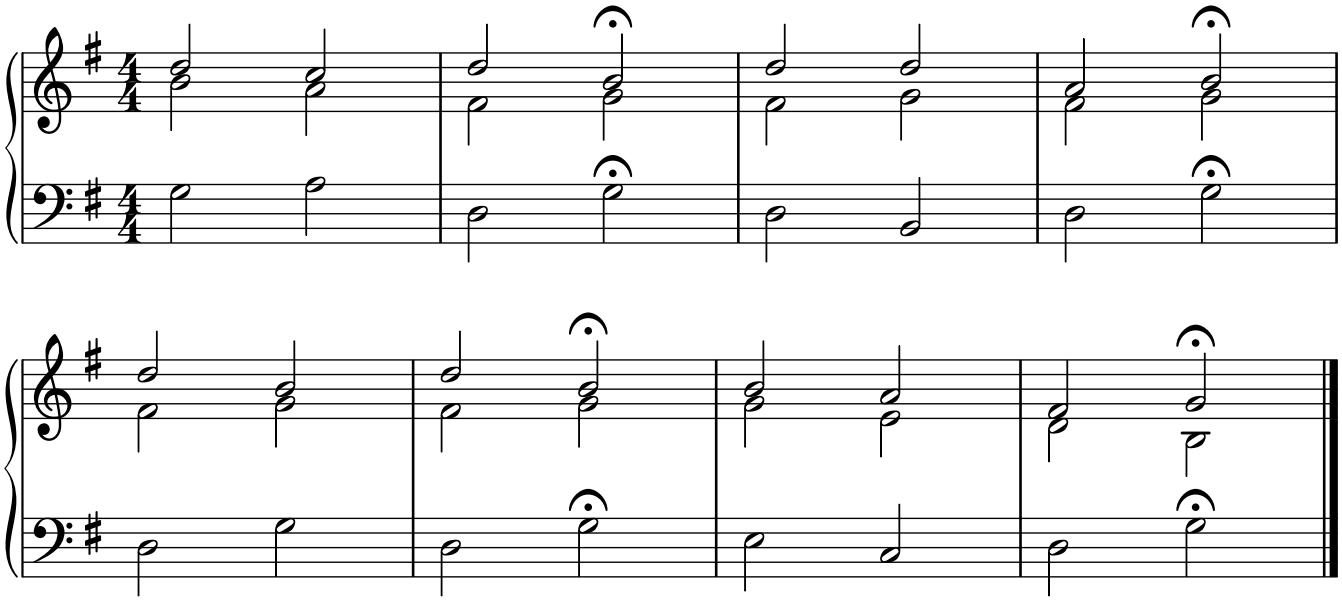
Part A: Three voices in half notes ♩ = 60

Three voices in half notes: soprano and alto in the right hand, the bass in the left. C, G and F major.

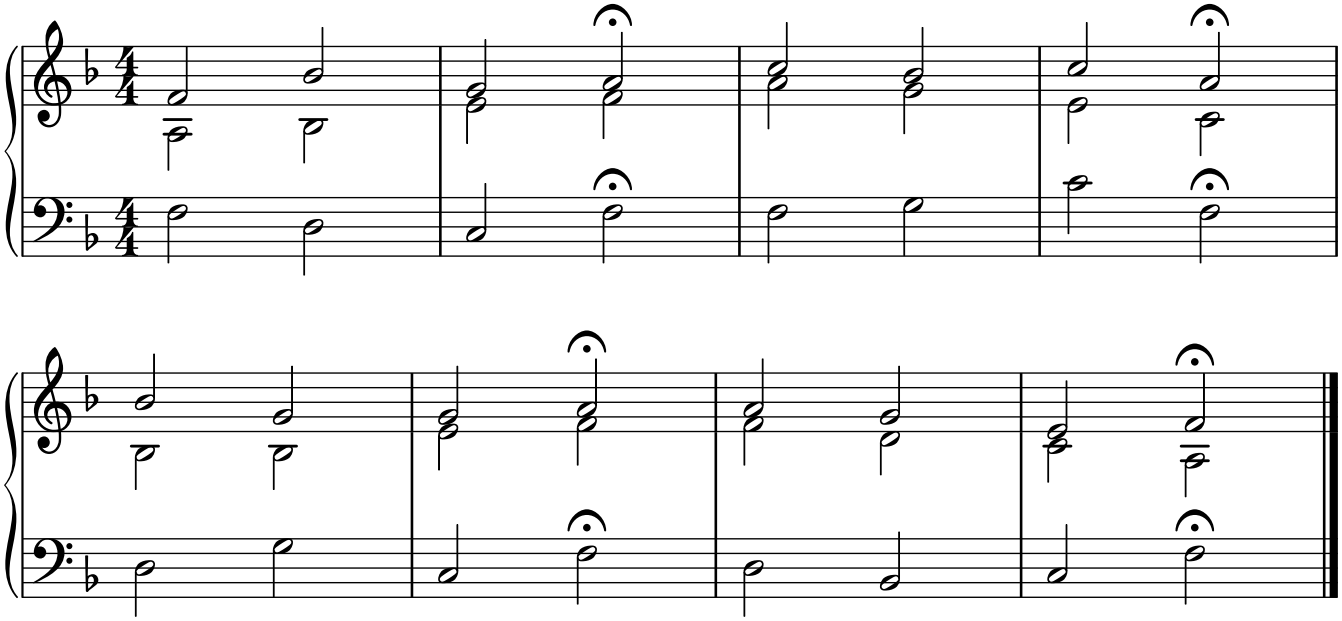
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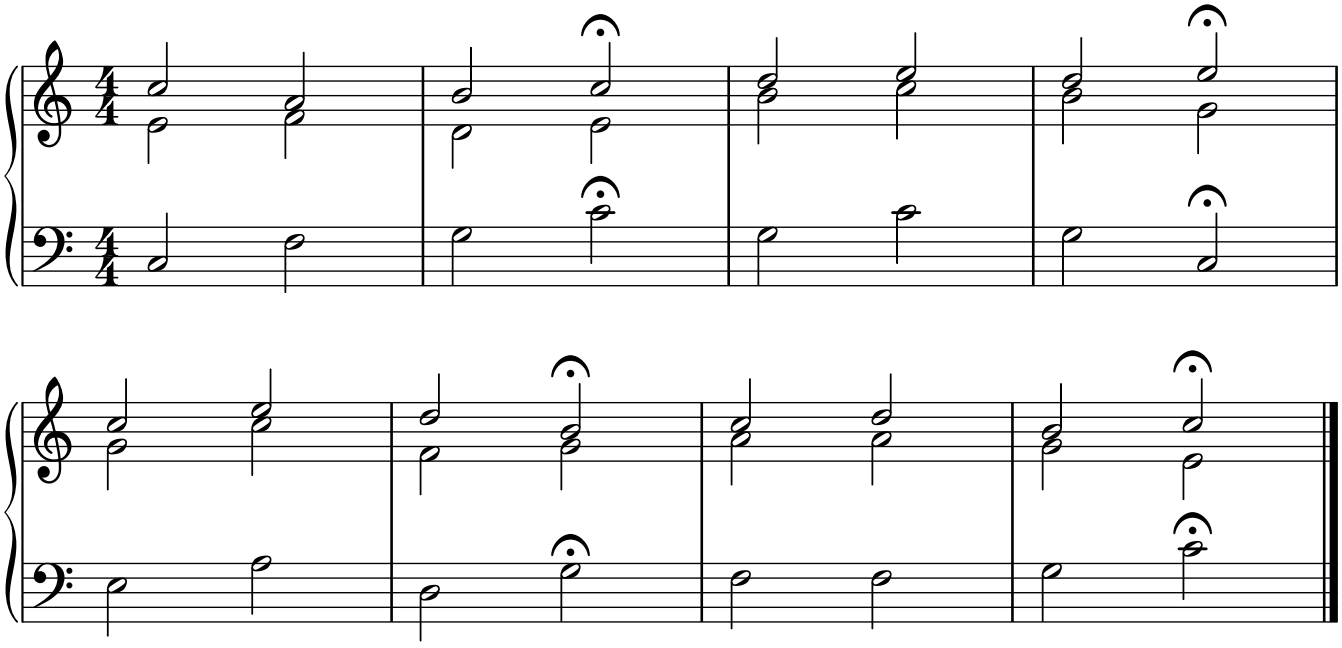


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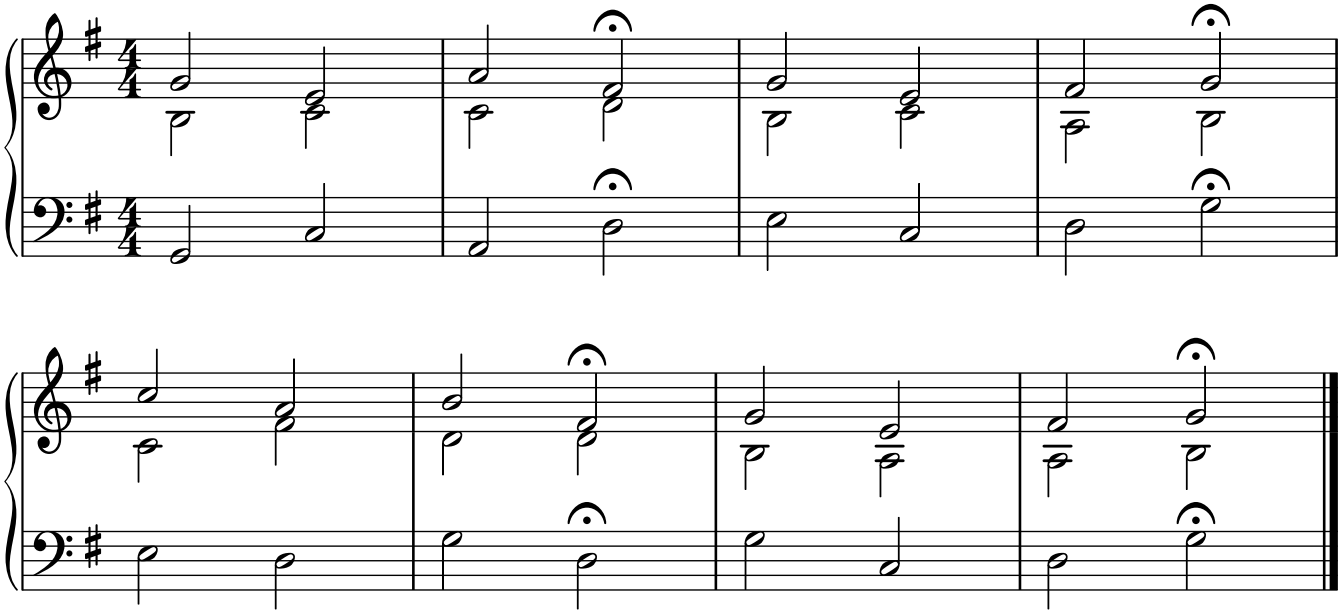


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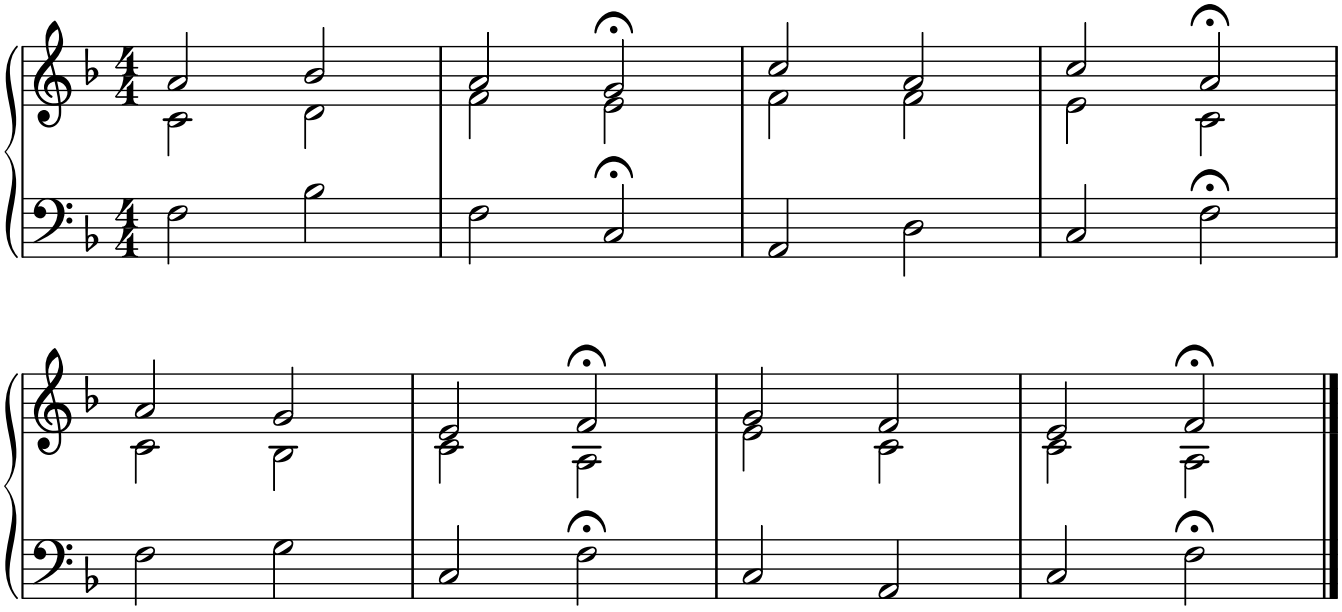


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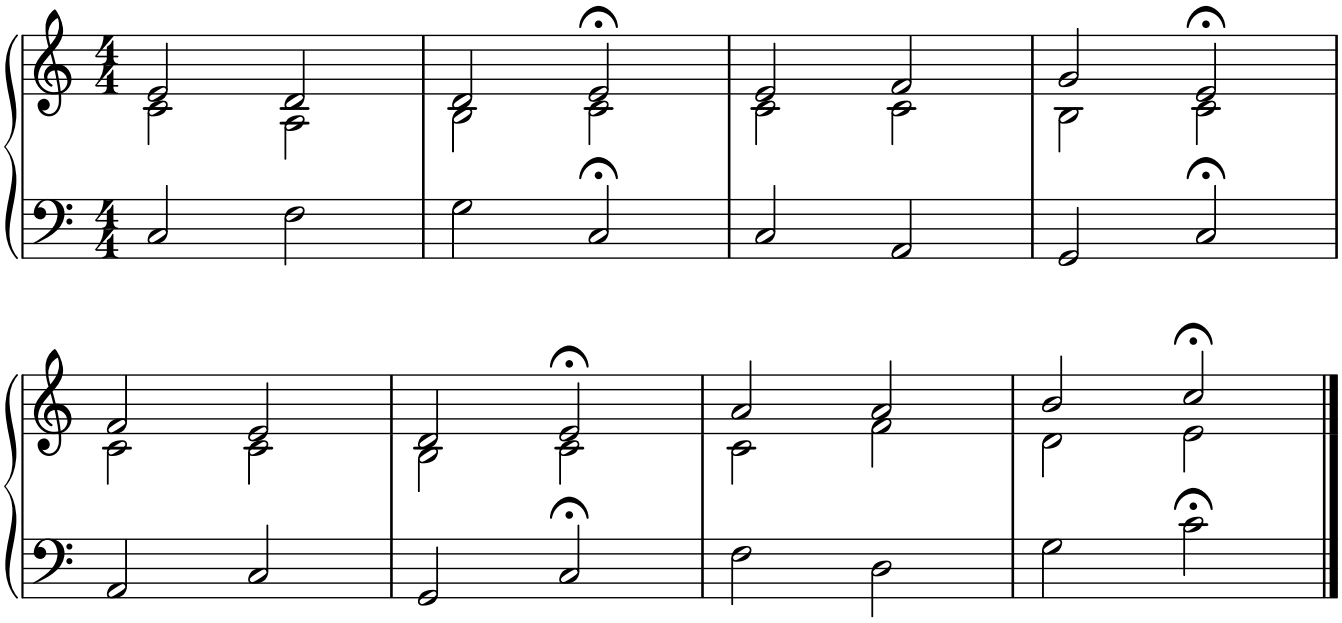


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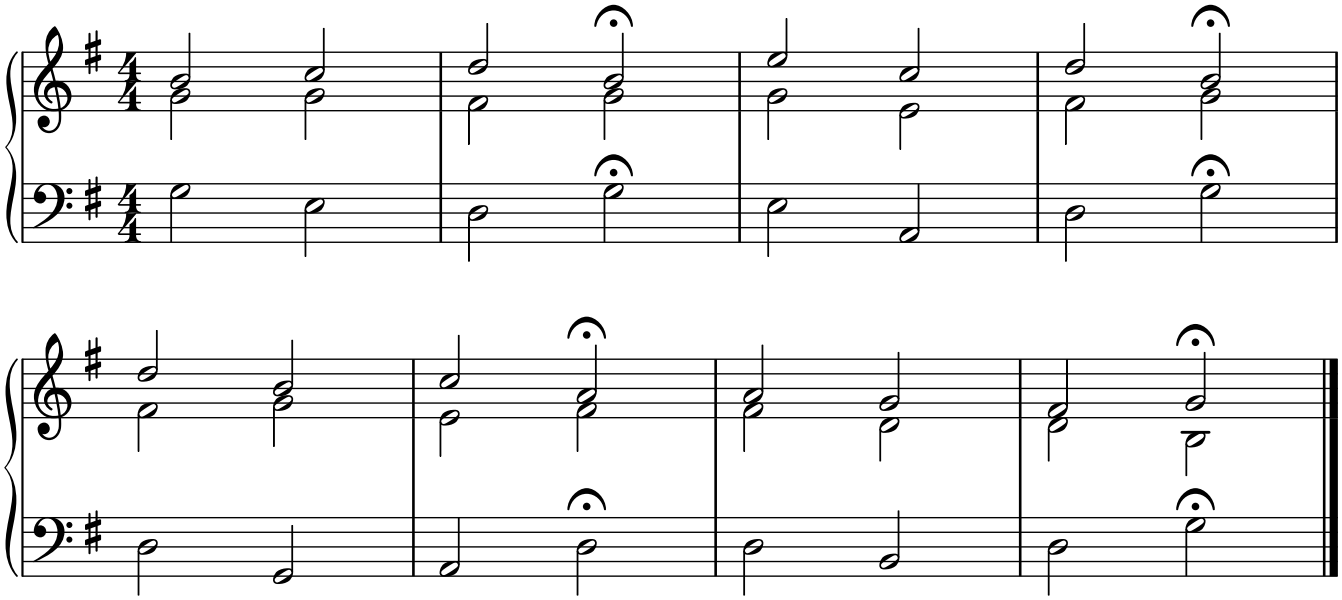
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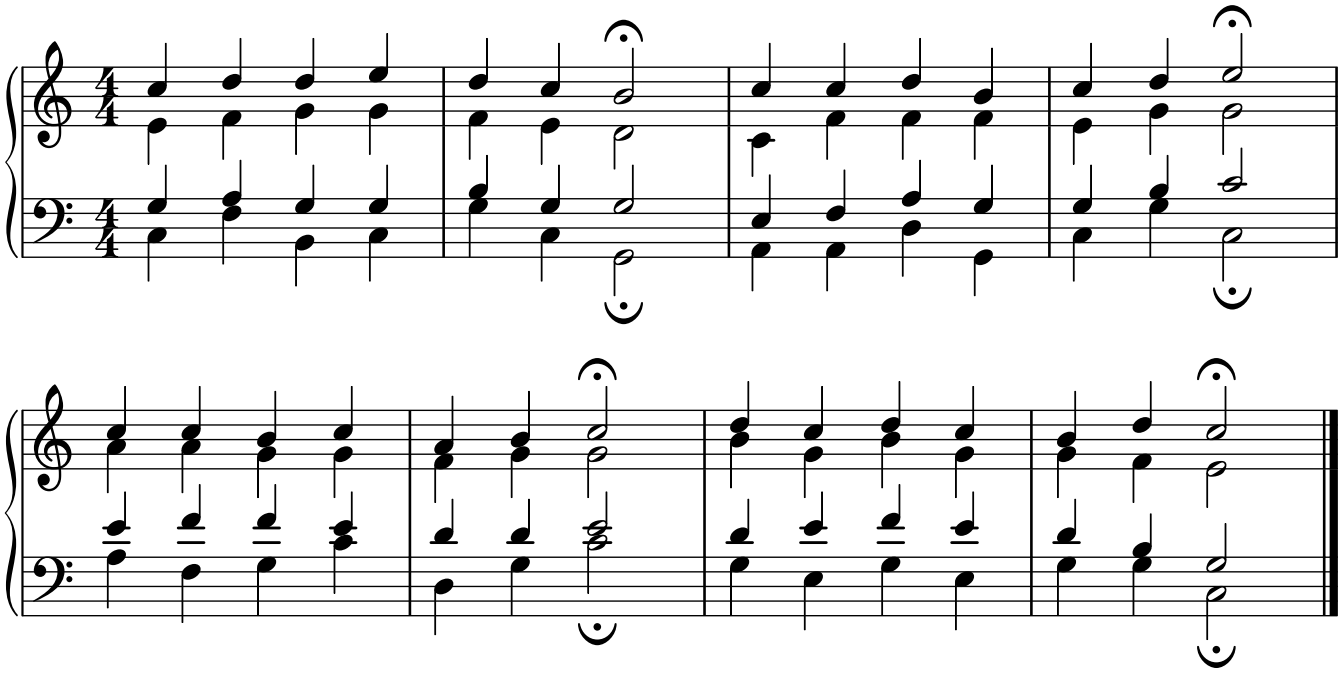


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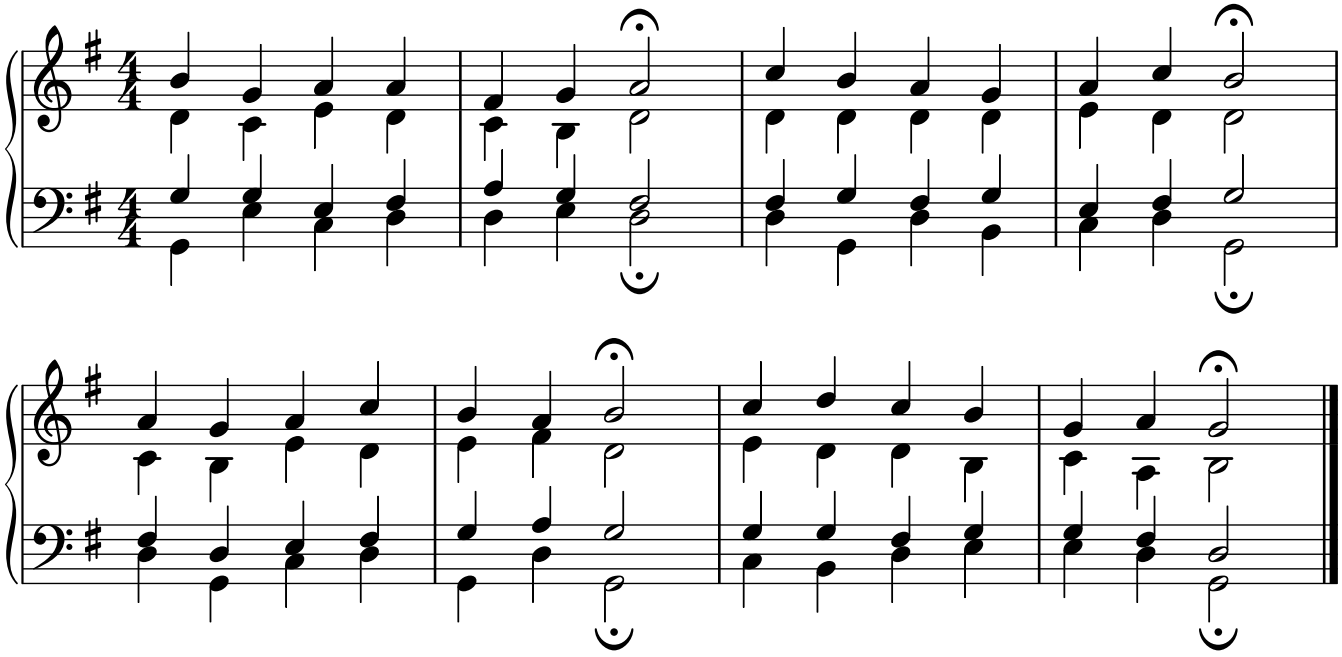


Part B: Four voices (SATB) ♩ = 60

Four voices in quarter notes, with fermatas at the end of each line. Look out for first inversions and for ii and vi. Keys with up to two sharps or flats.

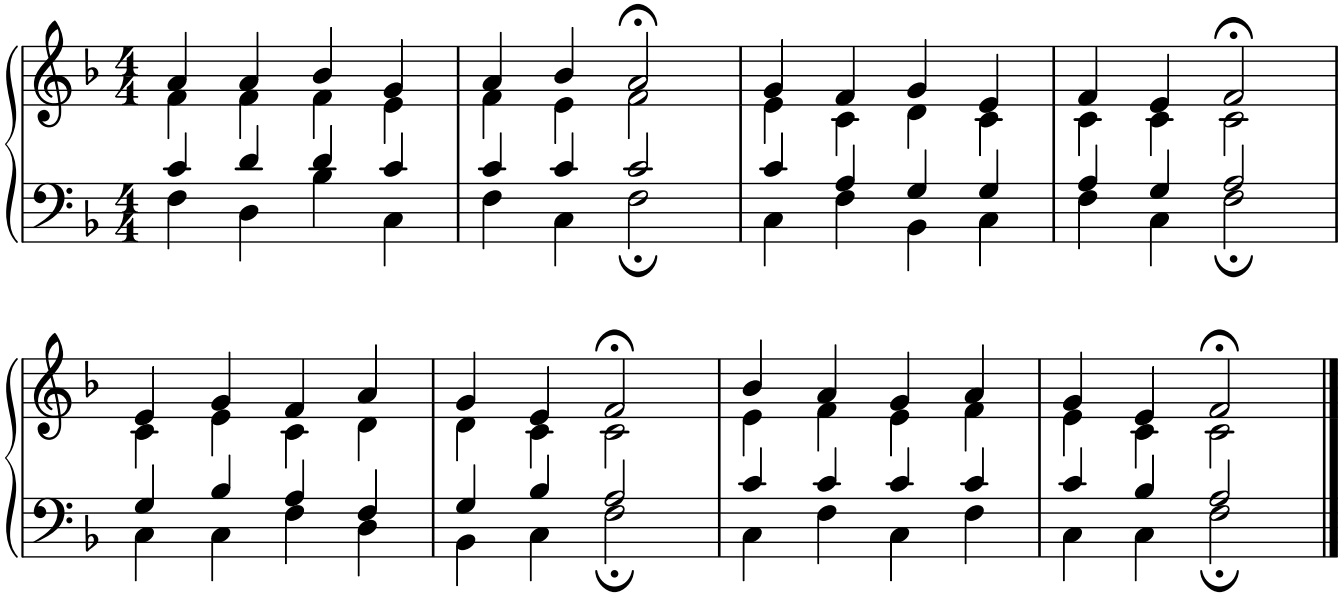
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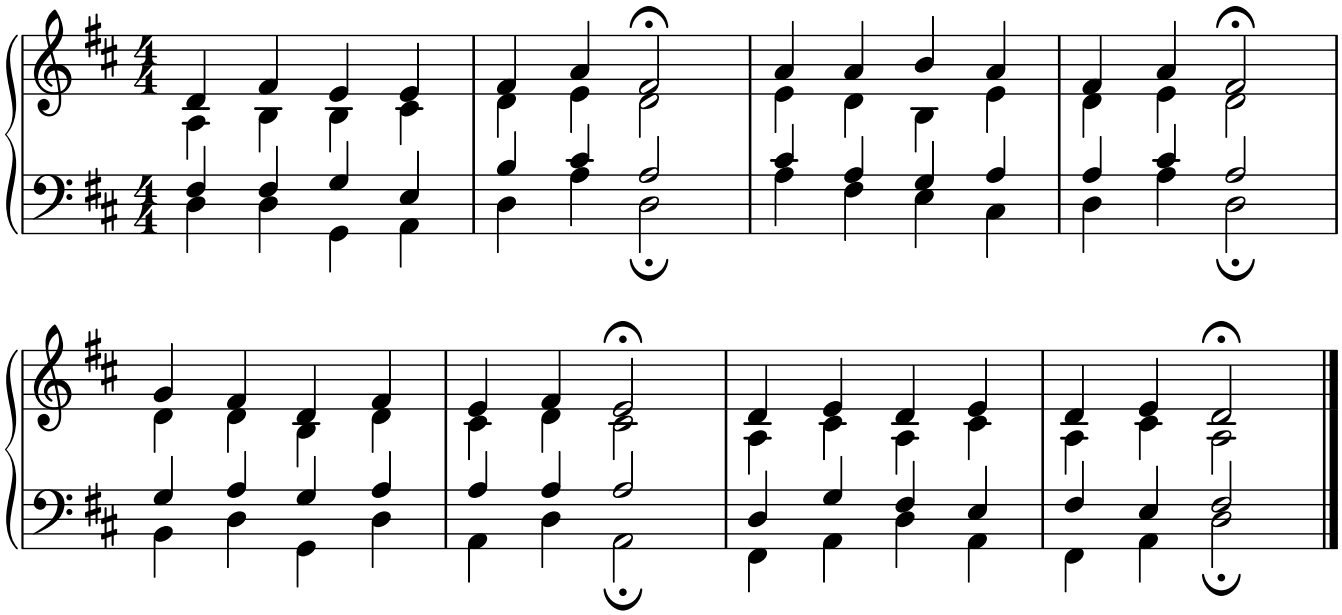
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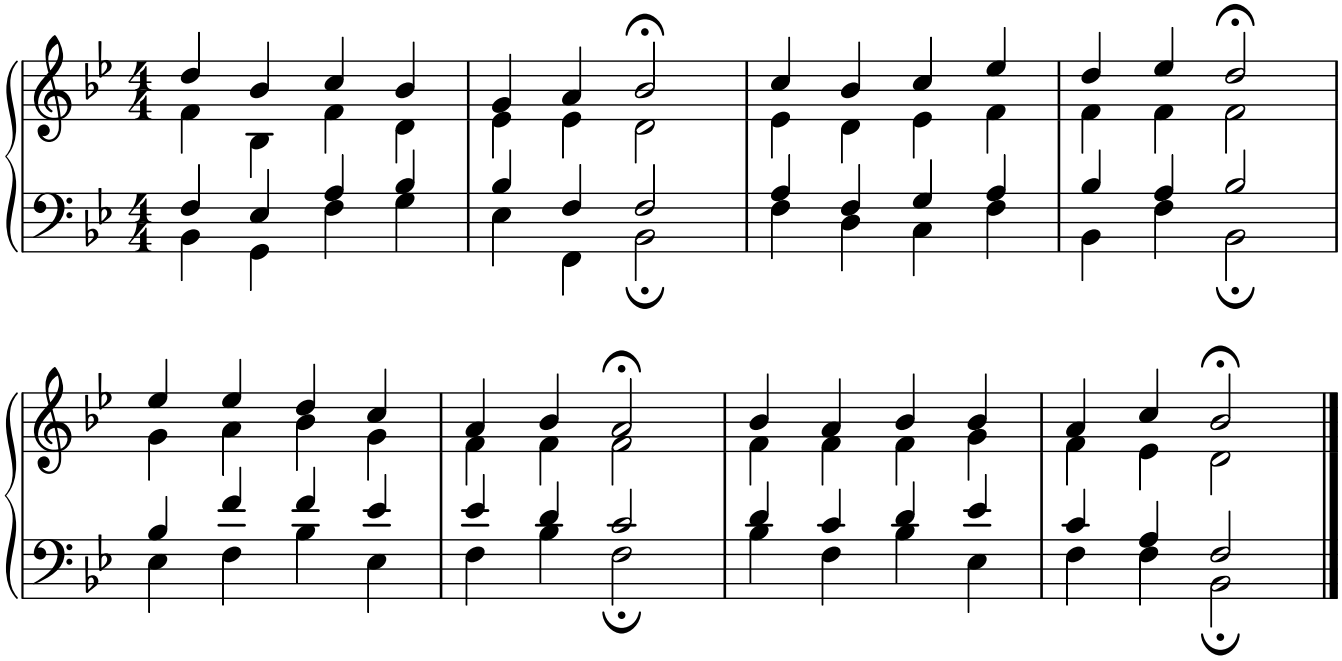


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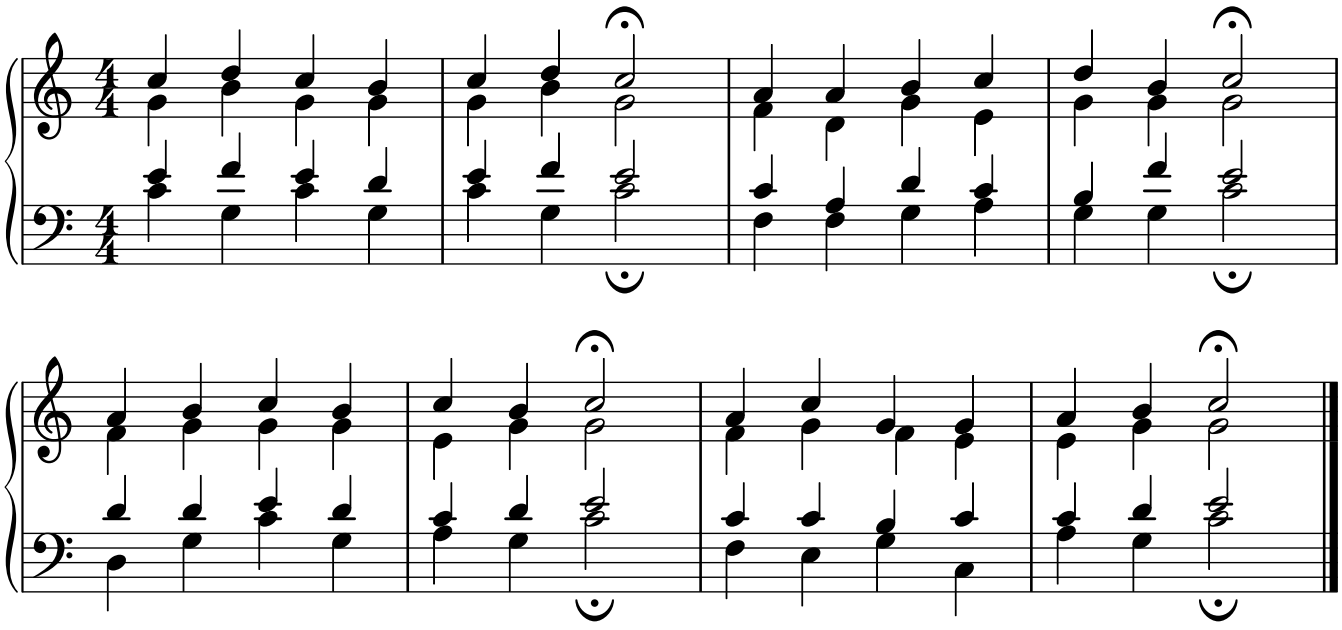
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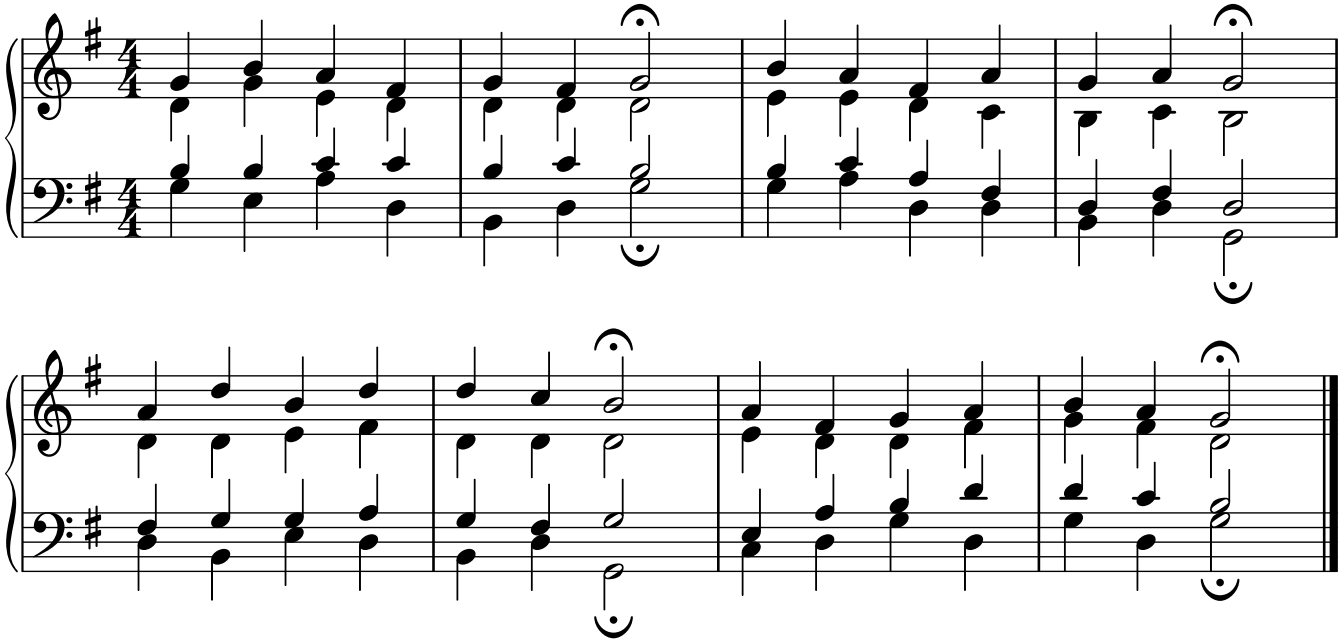


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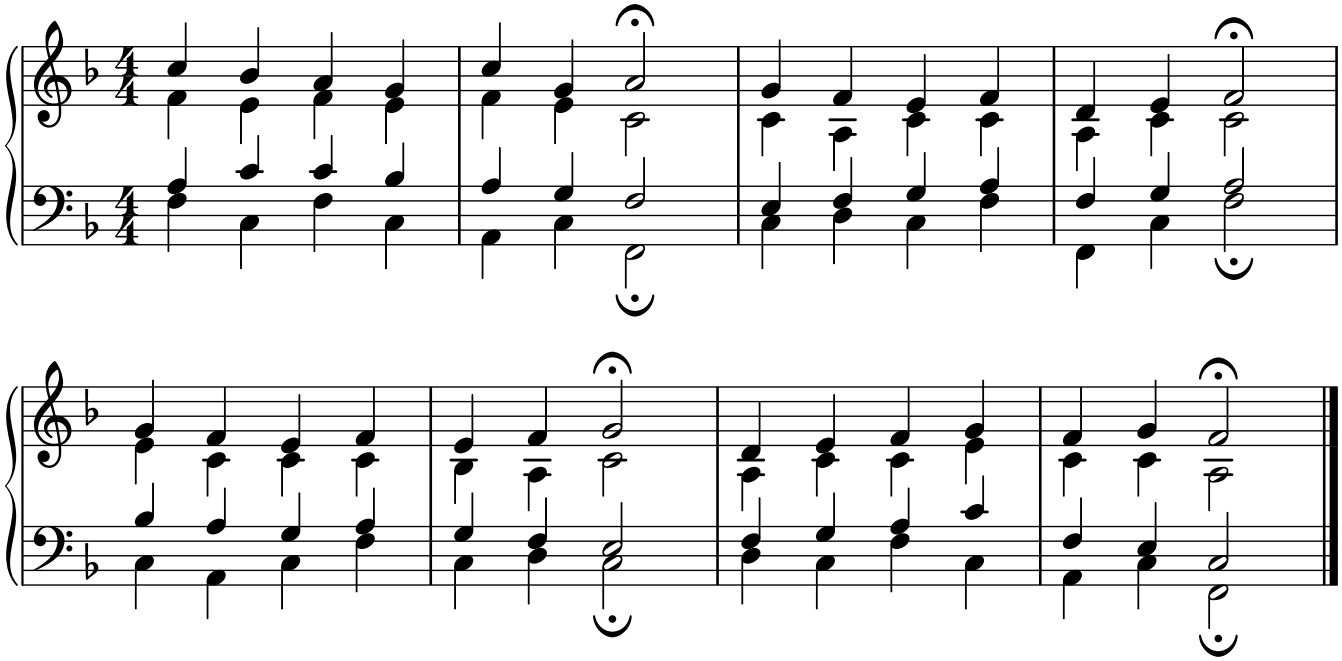
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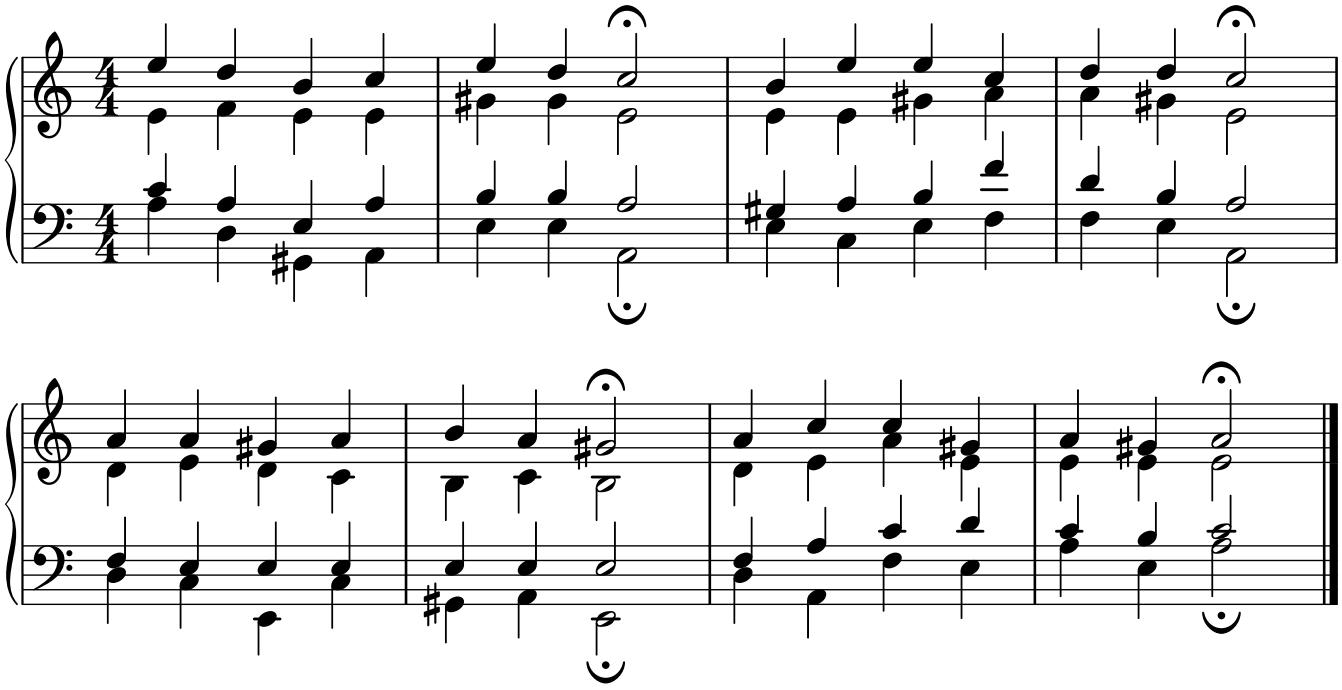


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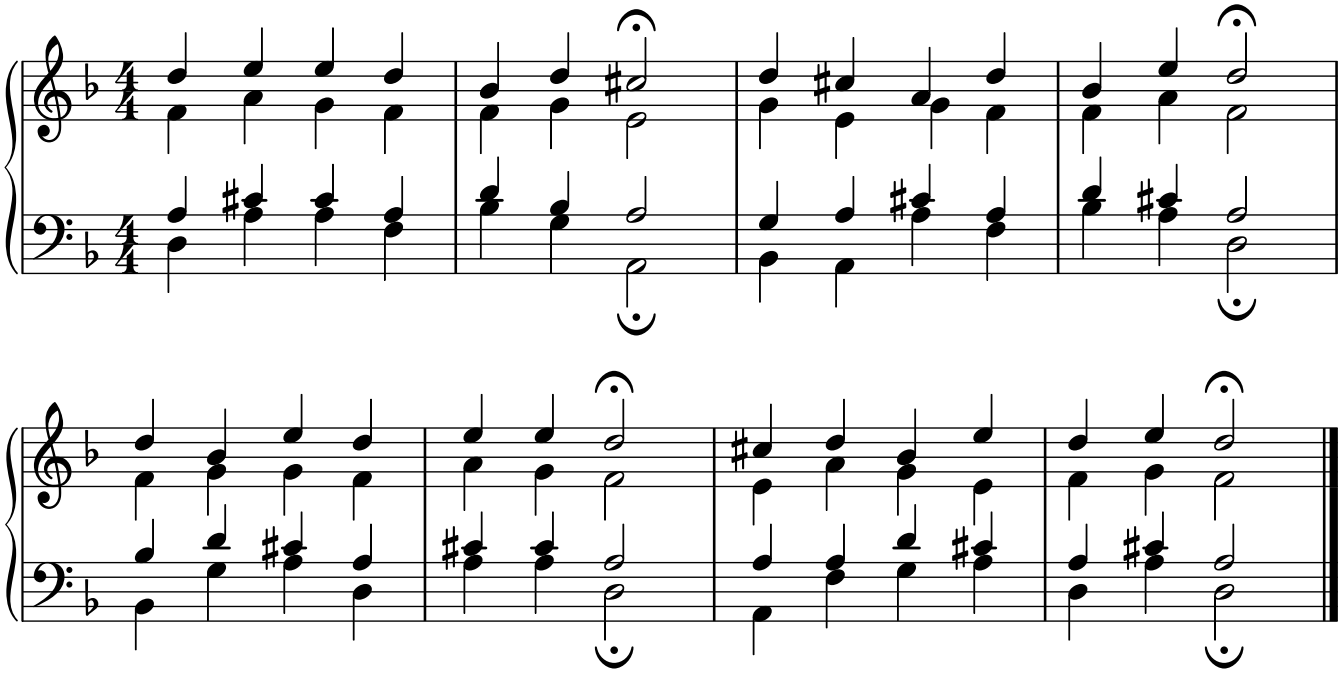


Part C: Chorales in minor keys ♩ = 60

Four-voice chorales in A, D and E minor. The raised 7th (G-sharp, C-sharp, D-sharp) appears in every V chord.
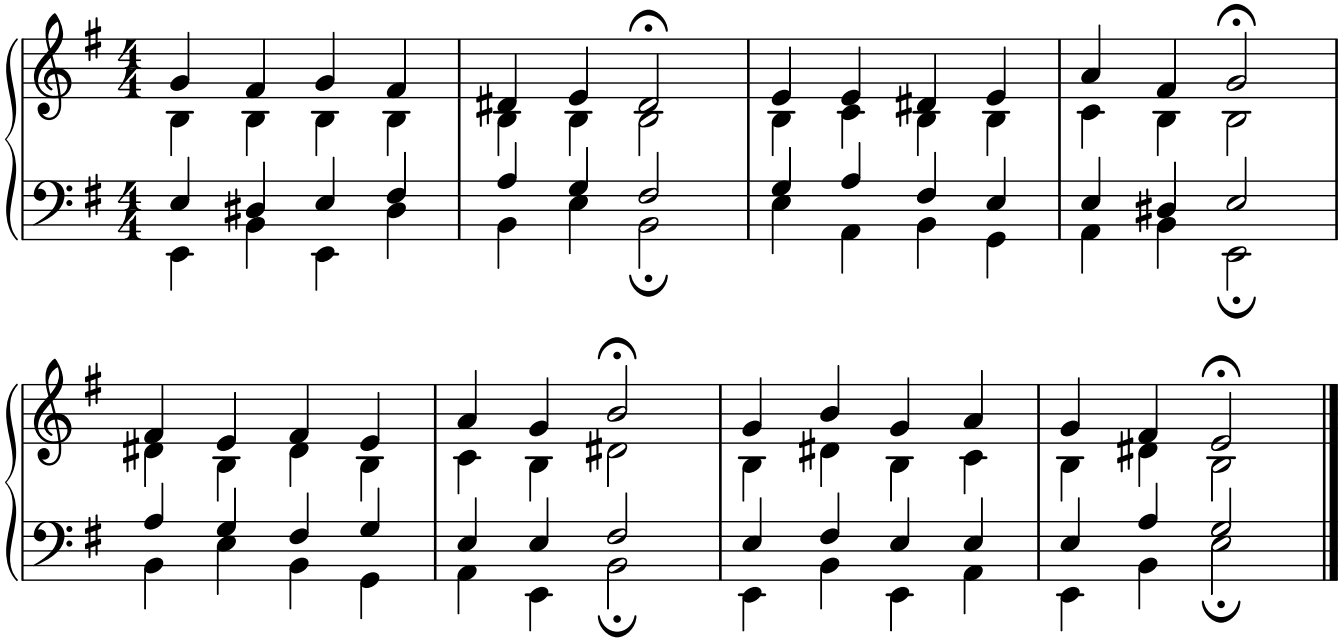
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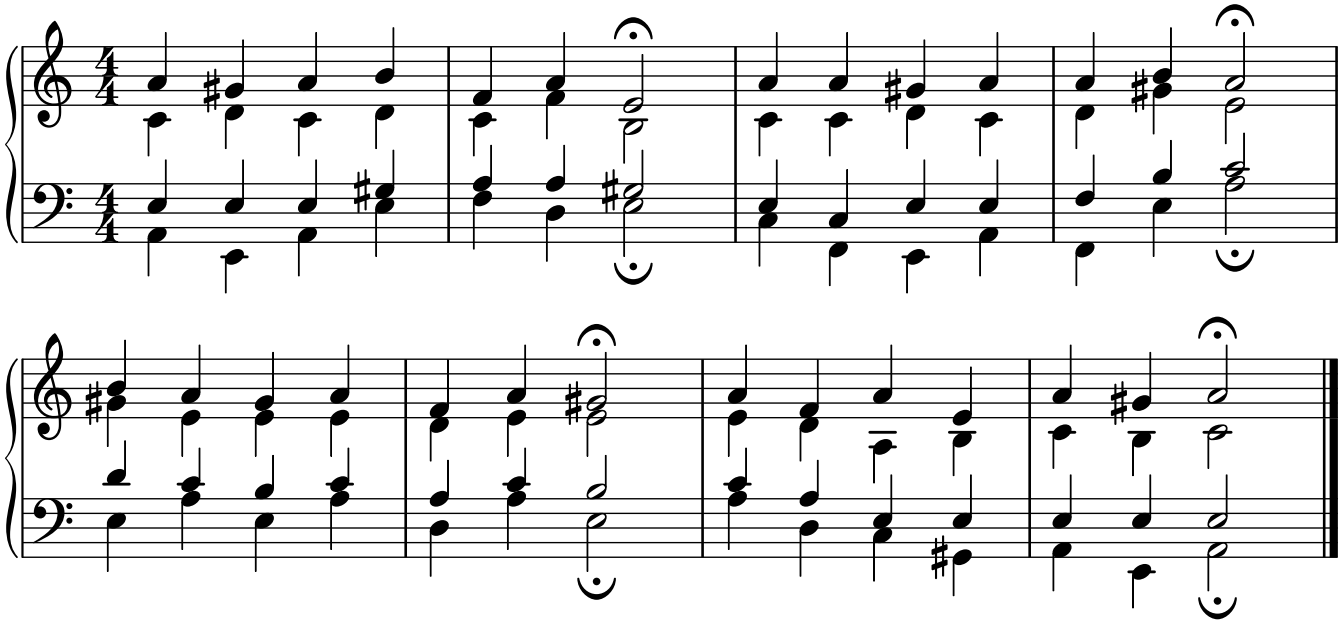


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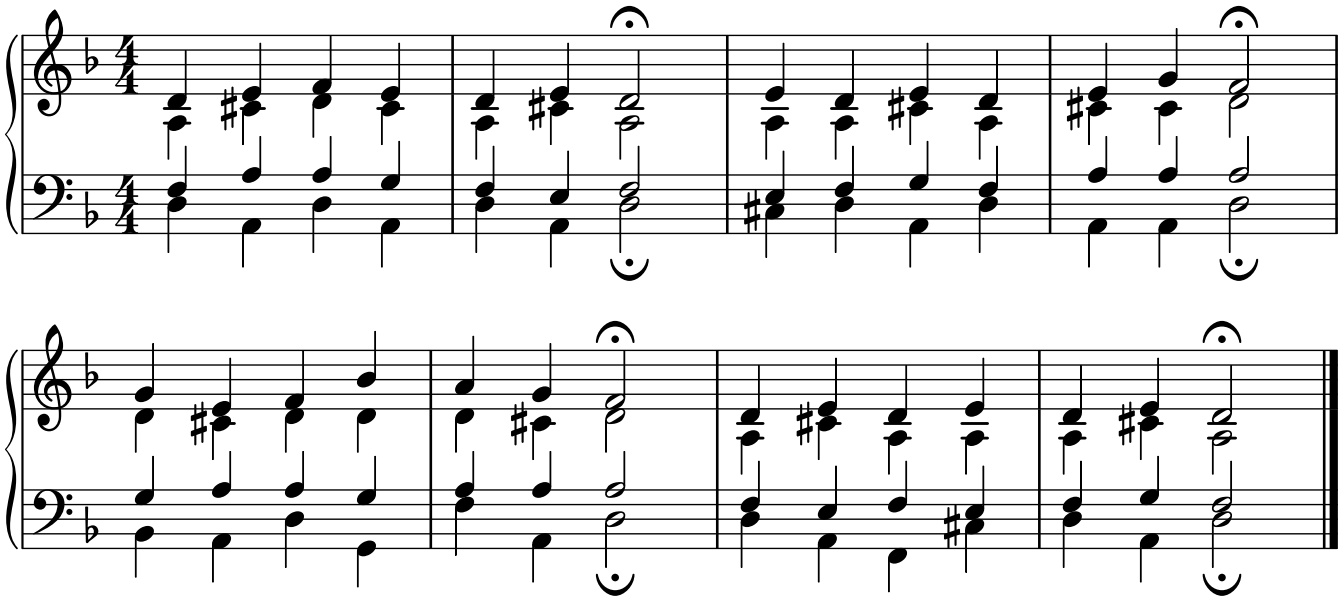
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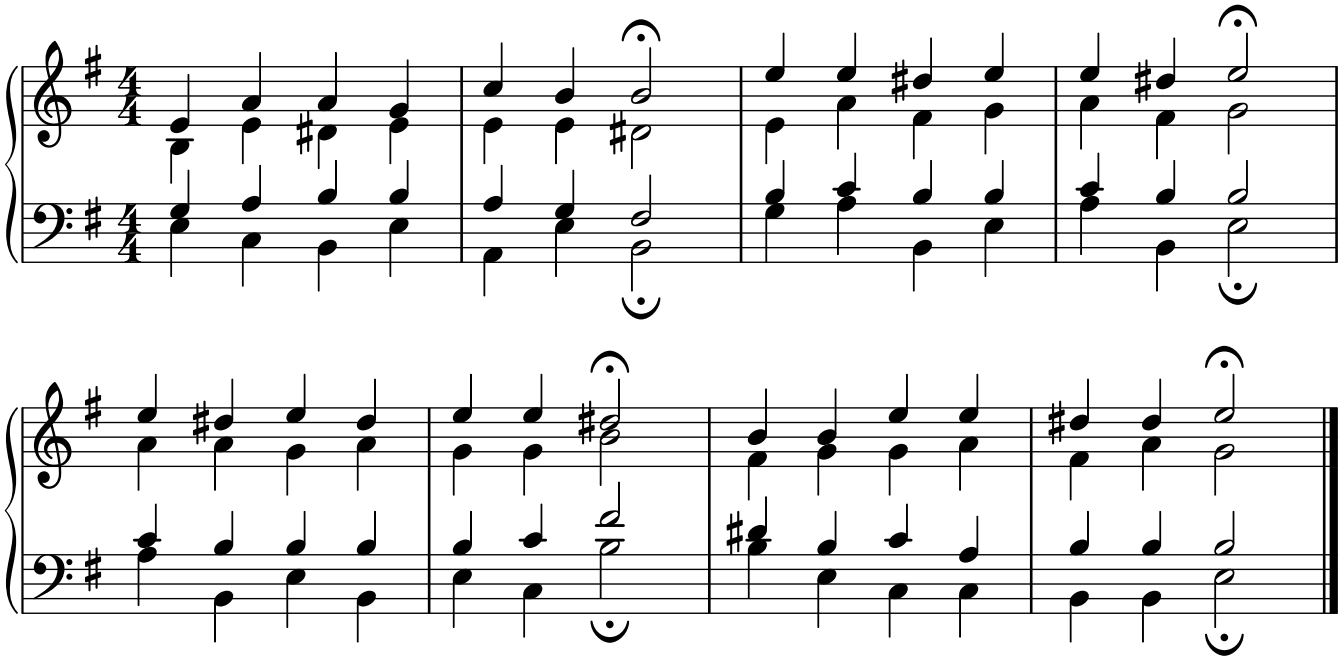


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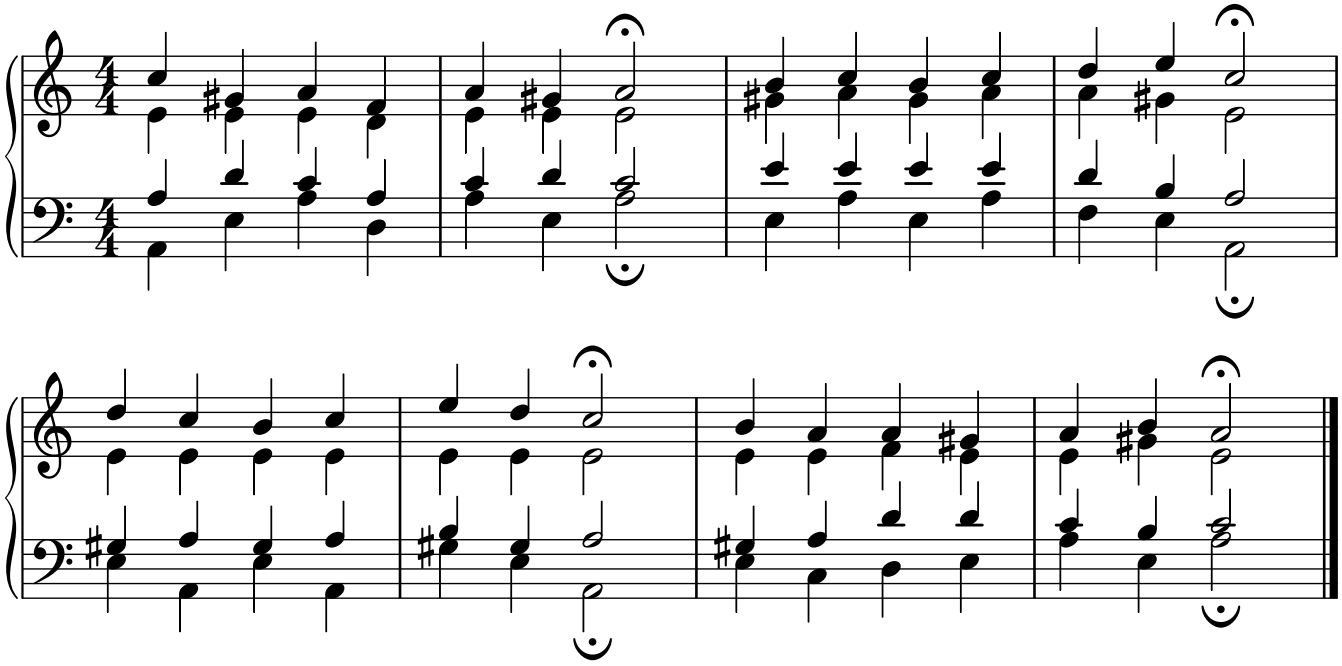


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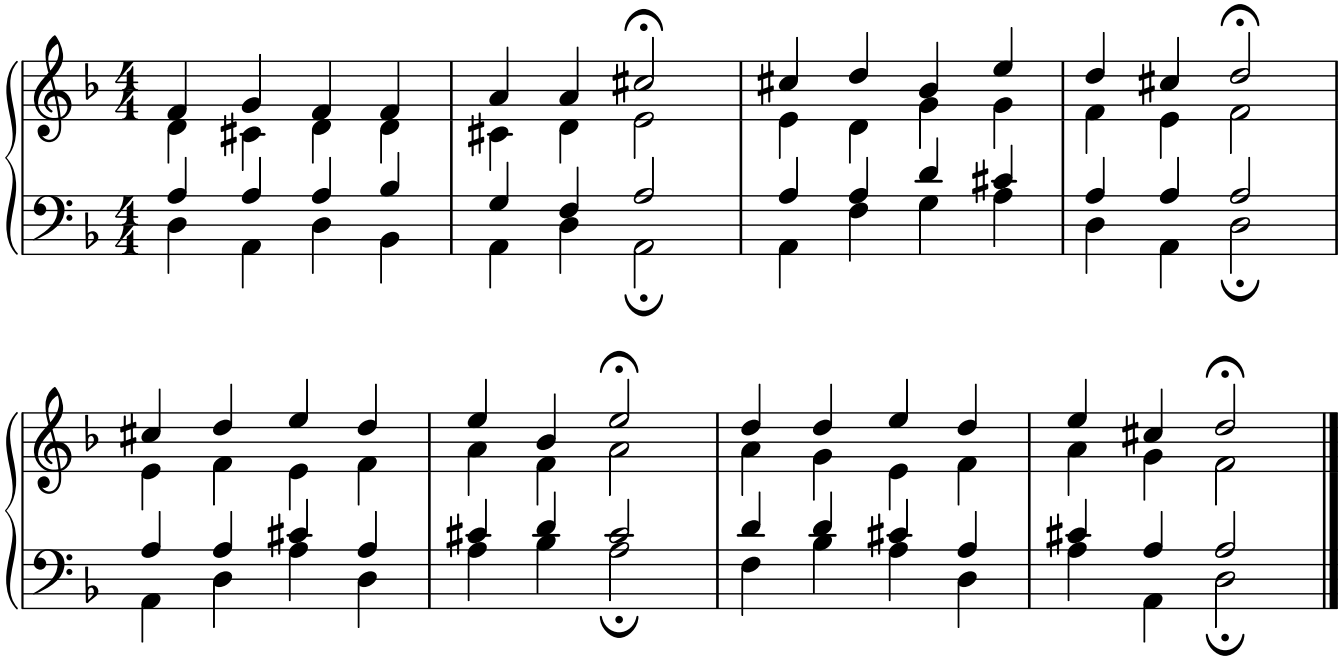


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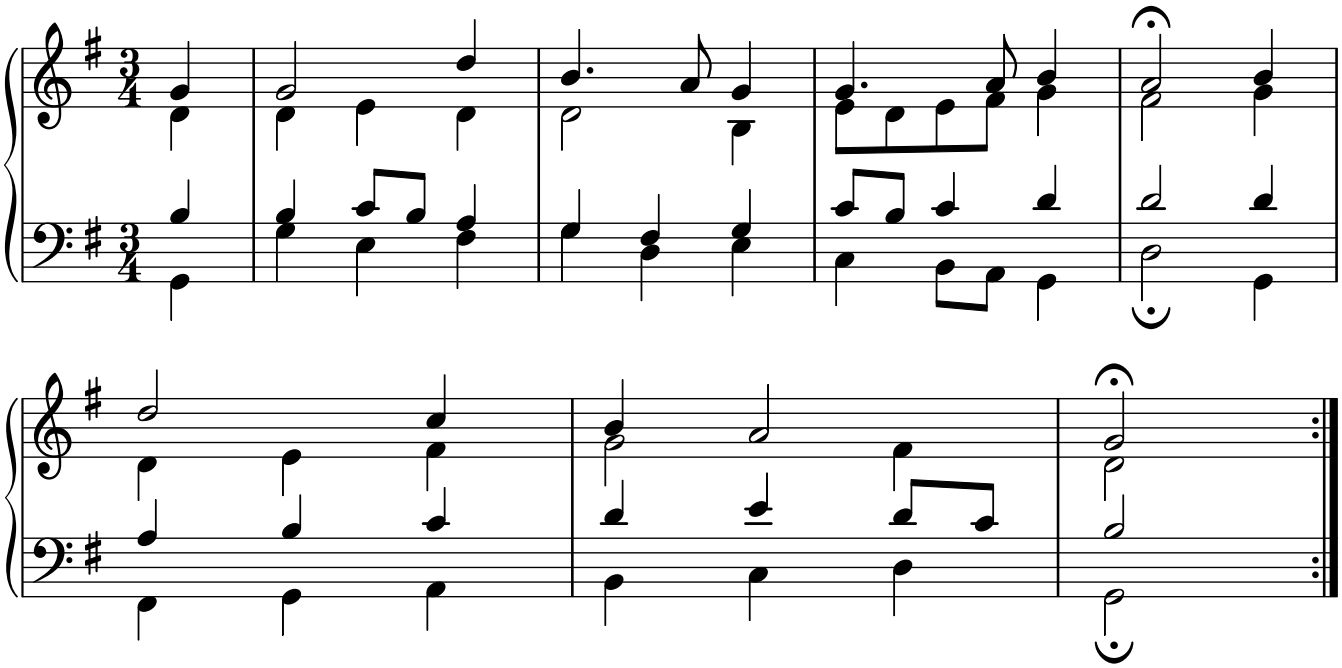


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Aus meines Herzens Grunde ♩ = 72

J. S. Bach, chorale, BWV 269 - first two lines
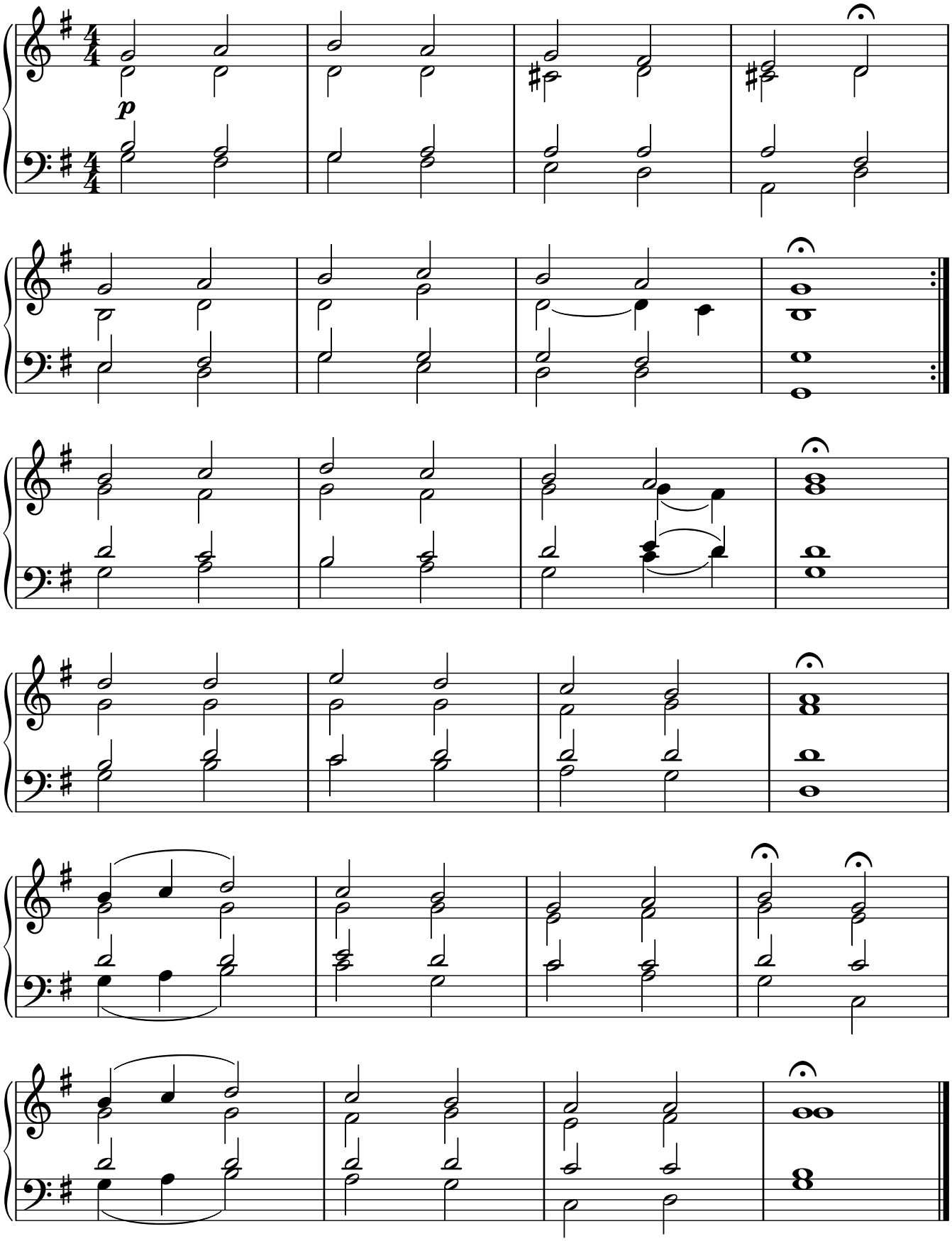
A chorale in 3/4 that begins with an upbeat (one beat before the first bar line). Play the whole passage twice, as the repeat sign asks. The tenor and bass are often more than an octave apart: take the tenor with the right hand wherever the left hand cannot reach. Source: Mutopia Project no. 378 (public domain).



Chorale ♩ = 92

Robert Schumann (1848), Album for the Young, Op. 68 No. 4 - complete
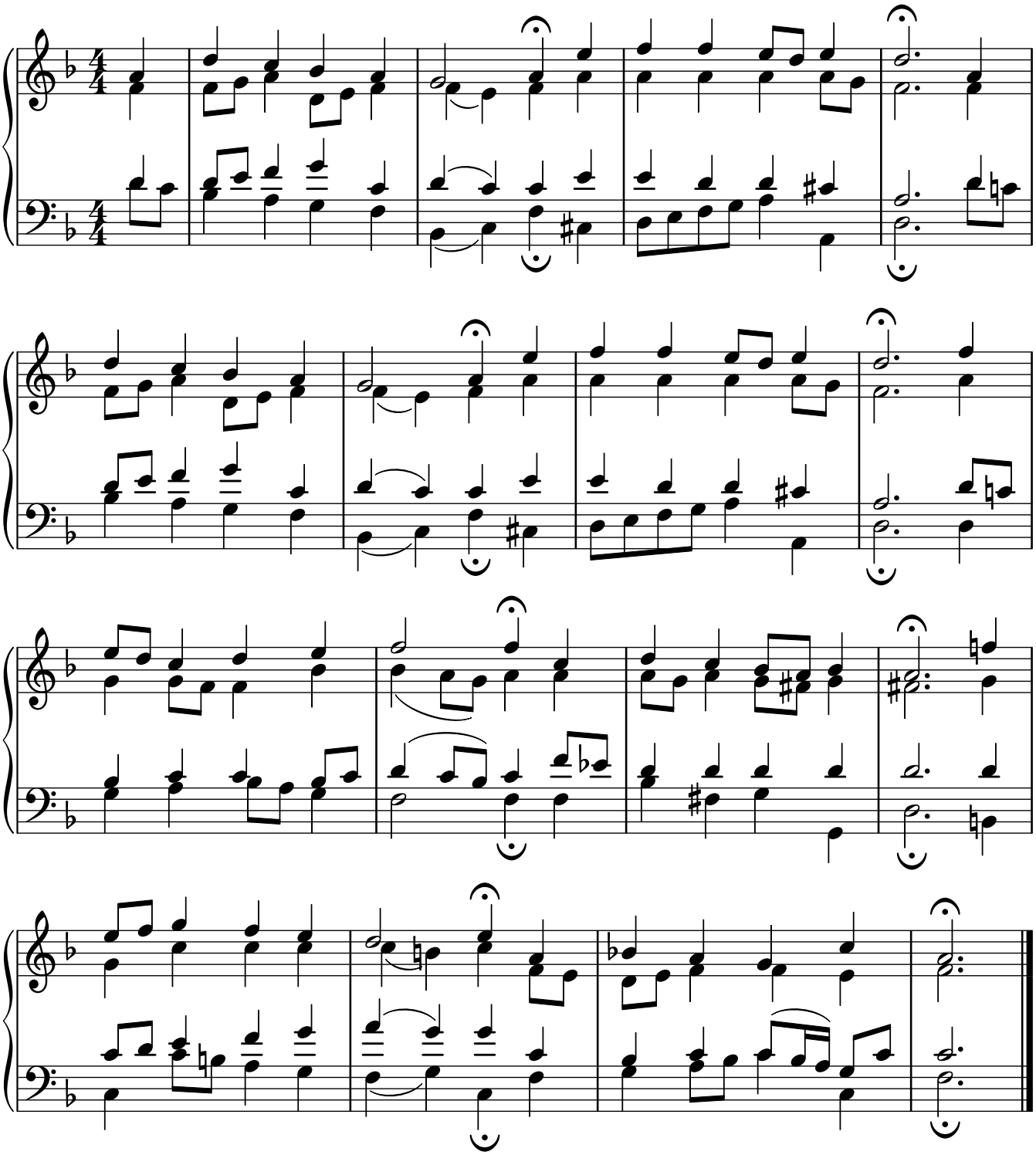
Schumann's setting of the chorale 'Freue dich, o meine Seele', in half notes: each half note is a new chord. Play bars 1-8 twice. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 782 by Philippe Hezaine (CC BY-SA 2.5).



O Haupt voll Blut und Wunden ♩= 60

J. S. Bach, chorale from the St Matthew Passion - complete
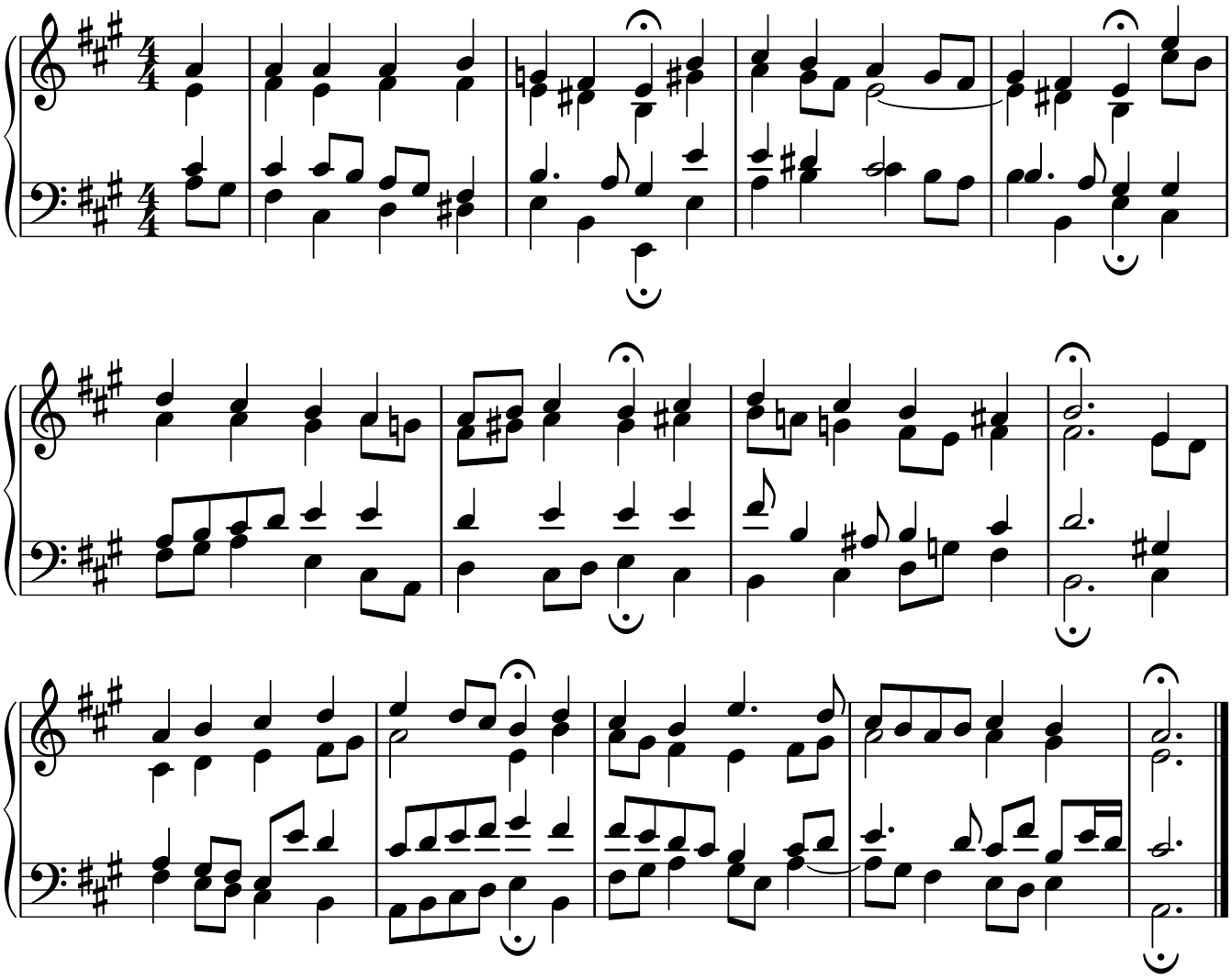
The Passion Chorale. It begins in D minor and ends on an F major chord. C-sharp is the raised 7th of D minor; F-sharp in bar 11 leads to G minor. Bach often puts the tenor more than an octave above the bass: wherever your left hand cannot reach both, take the tenor note with the right hand. Source: Mutopia Project no. 107 (public domain).



Ich dank dir, lieber Herre ♩ = 66

J. S. Bach, chorale, BWV 347 - complete, without the repeat

Three sharps: F, C and G. In bar 2 Bach writes G-natural for a moment; in bar 7 A-sharp leads to B minor. The tenor has a few eighth notes and two sixteenths of its own: keep them light. Where the left hand cannot reach, take the tenor with the right hand. Source: Mutopia Project no. 379 (public domain).



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 3?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if you can say, before you play, which bars end with a fermata and whether each of those lines ends on I or on V.
- Pass if you can read the Bach chorale 'Aus meines Herzens Grunde' at sight with soprano and bass, then with all four voices after a few days.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 3.